

AAC foundations, *for the team.*

A quick reference for everyone supporting one student who uses TouchChat with WordPower.

The whole job in one sentence: model language on his device, honor every attempt to communicate, and keep his voice ready and in reach — the same way, at home and at school. Everything below is how to do that well.

1 What AAC is

AAC is **everything but speech**. His device carries the most, but signs, gestures, and pointing all count as communication, and none of it waits for the device to be perfect. Respond to every form.

2 What he uses: TouchChat with WordPower

WordPower is a **word-based** vocabulary — built to make sentences on the fly, not just pick single pictures. It is organized around **core words** and was designed by a speech-language pathologist (Nancy Inman). It grows with him, from a handful of words up to a full keyboard. Ask his SLP which WordPower level he uses so your modeling matches his layout.

3 Core words, and why the layout never moves

A few hundred **core words** (want, stop, more, go, help, that, different, done) do about 80% of all talking — small, reusable, and useful everywhere. **Fringe words** (pizza, Minecraft, recess) are specific but each fits only one moment. Model core first: a core word works in every situation.

Never rearrange the buttons. A fluent user finds a word by muscle memory, the way you find a key on a keyboard. Moving a button erases that memory. Changes go through the SLP; hide or mask cells rather than deleting; keep the same word in the same spot every day, home and school.

4 Modeling — the one skill that matters most

A child hears a language for about a year before their first word. Modeling gives the device that same fair start: **talk while touching the words.**

Do

- Touch one or two key words as you say them.
- Model to show, not to quiz.
- Model, then wait a silent ten.
- Honor every attempt as real communication.

Skip

- Quizzing ("what's this?", "show me").
- "Use your words" — model the word instead.
- Moving or hiding buttons on your own.
- Treating exploration as misuse — it's babbling.

For the behavior team: modeling is aided language input, and it's errorless — no demand, no wrong answer, no extinction burst.

Behavior & academics.

Reading his communication, and giving him access to the whole curriculum.

5 Behavior is communication

Every challenging behavior is a message: escape means "I need out," attention means "talk to me," tangible means "I want that," sensory means "too loud." Teach the word on his device and the behavior loses its job — that is functional communication training. It maps onto what the behavior team already does well: errorless teaching, prompt fading, replacement behaviors, and data.

When it escalates, three moves: stop talking (three words or fewer), model rather than demand, and honor the message every time, in any form.

The escape question: honoring a break request doesn't add escape — he already escapes by melting down. You're changing the route to a communicative one. Fade duration later; never fade the reliability of the request. A printed de-escalation board is a low-tech backup when the device can't be reached — a bridge, not a replacement.

6 AAC for academics

Requesting is the floor, not the ceiling. A device that only asks for snacks and breaks is a remote control, not a voice. Academic access means he can comment, answer, question, compare, and object about any lesson. The key idea: **one flexible core word does academic work in every subject** — he doesn't need a new word for each lesson. "More than" in math, "it changed" in science, "what happens" in reading.

Four moves that work in any lesson:

- **Model during instruction** — touch core words on his system as you teach.
- **Word of the week** — saturate every subject with one core word for a week.
- **Describe, don't label-hunt** — "it's big and fast" with core generalizes; hunting for the exact noun doesn't.
- **Ask real questions, then wait** — "What do you think?" then a silent ten. Presume he has something to say.

The long game is **literacy**: WordPower's keyboard opens every word in the language as his spelling grows. Model letters the way you model core, and keep alphabet access available.



The VOICE check — five seconds, every setting. Before each activity, home and school: Visible, On, In reach, Charged, Every setting. A device in the backpack is a voice that can't ask for anything.